

Through the Void: The Absence of God in R. Nahman of Bratzlav's *Likkutei MoHaRa*¹

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Although not usually viewed as a manifestation of modern spirituality, Hasidism strikingly resembles a product of the spiritual and ideological reorientation of Western religion in the post-Copernican world.² Largely unaware of the philosophical and theological changes in European intellectual culture, many of the hasidic masters exhibited a sensitivity to the existential plight of humankind in the modern world.

¹Unless otherwise indicated, translations and italics throughout the article are mine.

²Martin Buber, Samuel Abba Horodetzky, and Hillel Zeitlin introduced hasidism to the modern world. Buber's early studies on hasidic thought were directed at the larger scholarly audience in Europe with the hope that hasidism would serve as a Jewish component in the mystical revival at the turn of the century. This is true to a lesser extent for Horodetzky and Zeitlin. See, for example, Horodetzky's comparative study of R. Nahman and Schleiermacher, "Rabbi Nachman von Bratzlav: Beitrag zur Geschichte der jüdischen Mystik," in Steven Katz, ed., *Studies by Samuel Horodezky* (New York: Arno, 1980); Hillel Zeitlin, *Rabbi Nahman mi-Bratzlav: Hayav u-Torato* (Warsaw: n.p., 1910); and idem, *Reb Nakhman Braslaver* (New York: Harper, 1952). See also Martin Buber, *The Legend of the Baal Shem Tov* (1908; trans. Maurice Friedman; New York: Harper, 1955); and idem, *The Tales of Rabbi Nahman* (1906; trans. Maurice Friedman; Atlantic Highlands, NJ: Humanities Press International, 1988). On the contribution of hasidism in general and R. Nahman in particular to modern Western spirituality, see idem, "Spinoza, Sabbatai Zvi, and the Baal Shem," in idem, *The Origin and Meaning of Hasidism* (Atlantic Highlands, NJ: Humanities Press International, 1988) 89–112; idem, "The Place of Hasidism in the History of Religion," in idem, *The Origin and Meaning of Hasidism*, 219–39; and Joseph Weiss, "Sense and Non-Sense in Defining Judaism—The Strange Case of Nahman of Bratzlav," in idem, *Studies in East European Jewish Mysticism* (ed. David Goldstein; Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1985) 249–69.

It must be stated at the outset that any analysis of hasidism and its ideological symmetry to modern thought must begin by recognizing the divergent and multifarious nature of hasidic spirituality. Contemporary scholarship has rendered any overarching statement about hasidism obsolete. The hasidic movement contained and still contains numerous strains, differentiated by various schools of thought that flourished in Eastern Europe from the mid-eighteenth century until the present.³ Thus, any conclusions drawn from my analysis of one very provocative hasidic thinker, R. Naḥman of Bratzlav (1772–1810), should not be viewed as a statement regarding hasidism in general.

The life and thought of R. Naḥman of Bratzlav is particularly striking in its sensitivity to the struggle of one who seeks God in the very realm of God's absence. In this sense he is unique among early hasidic thinkers, many of whom adopted a more acosmic stance, where God's absence was viewed as an illusion to be overcome by means of devotion, culminating in an experience of communion with God (*devekut*). It is therefore not surprising that, whereas most hasidic masters at first attained legitimacy by being disciples of a particular master, R. Naḥman's reputation is based largely on the originality of this thought.⁴ This theme of divine absence and the struggle to overcome it places R. Naḥman squarely in the company of some of the more provocative theistic existentialists of the eighteenth, nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. The paradigm shift from the medieval period's sense of the incomprehensibility of God to the human estrangement from God may be seen in light of the shift in orientation of early modern thought from the cosmos to the individual.⁵ Perhaps the most striking characteristic

³Joseph Weiss's typological analysis ("Contemplative Mysticism and 'Faith' in Hasidic Piety," in idem, *Studies*, 47–55) maintains that hasidism can be divided into two trends: "mystical hasidism" and "faith hasidism." While this is perhaps too simplistic, it does point to a useful distinction. Much of this theory rests on how much each hasidic school integrated and interpreted the medieval kabbalistic tradition.

⁴R. Naḥman was born into the family of the Baal Shem Tov (Besht), the founder of hasidism. His mother Feige was the granddaughter of the Baal Shem and his two uncles, R. Moshe Hayyim Ephraim of Sudikov (1737–1800) and R. Barukh of Medzhibozh (1750–1812) were leaders of Ukrainian hasidism at the end of the eighteenth century. His family lineage was important to him and he used it to legitimate his place in the annals of hasidism. Yet even as he was influenced by his uncles and their disciples, R. Naḥman did not consider himself to be a disciple of one particular master. He often portrayed himself as a self-made *zaddik*. For more on his early life, see Arthur Green, *Tormented Master: A Life of Rabbi Naḥman* (Woodstock, Vermont: Jewish Lights, 1992) 23–62.

⁵For a general discussion on this shift in modern theology, see Anthony T. Padovano, *The Estranged God: Modern Man's Search for Belief* (New York/Kansas City: Sheed & Ward, 1966); David Everett Roberts, *Existentialism and Religious Belief* (New York/Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1967); Ralph Harper, *On Presence: Variations and Reflections* (Philadelphia: Trinity, 1991); and John Wild and James M. Edie, eds., *Christianity and Existentialism: Essays by William Earle* (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press, 1963).

of R. Nahman is that his outlook reflects this shift without his being aware of its existence. Moreover, R. Nahman's "existential" stance, which was rooted in the sixteenth-century Jewish mystical tradition typical of early hasidism, emerged out of a theosophic worldview that did not easily lend itself to such an existential interpretation.⁶

In this article, I illuminate the hasidic treatment of divine absence in order to show how it offers a creative theistic Jewish response to the existentialist position of alienation rooted in traditional piety.⁷ The first part of this article includes an analysis of the theory of divine absence in R. Nahman, which is depicted as the divine void (*halal ha-panui*) in the theosophic kabbalism of the sixteenth-century Jewish mystic, R. Isaac Luria. I shall then attempt to place R. Nahman's position in the context of other modern theistic existentialists who grappled with similar issues, even as they reached different conclusions. I hope that the creative spiritual struggle of R. Nahman, which has remained largely inaccessible to the general schol-

⁶The question of how much R. Nahman integrated this kabbalistic worldview is a topic for another study. Although he used kabbalistic categories and jargon, it is difficult to determine how much his thinking reflects this medieval mystical tradition. Both Scholem and Buber agree—although from different perspectives—that early hasidism contributed little to furthering the kabbalistic agenda. See Gershom Scholem, *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism* (New York: Schocken, 1941) 338. While Scholem suggested that hasidism adopted kabbalistic ideas without offering anything "new," Martin Buber argued ("The Faith of Judaism," in idem, *Mamre: Essays in Religion* [trans., Greta Horn; Westport, CN: Greenwood, 1970] 13) that hasidism had overcome Kabbala in the same way he felt it had overcome talmudism: "The Kabbalah was overcome [in hasidism] because it was taken up into the ur-Jewish conception of the dialogical life just as it was. This overcoming of Kabbala is the important work of Chassidism; it left all middle-substances to fade before the relationship between God's transcendence, only to be called 'the limitless' with the suspension of all limited being, and his immanence, his 'indwelling.'" Although one can surely argue this point for the hasidic tradition of early Habad and the Polish school of Kamarno, Buber's sweeping claim resonates in R. Nahman's personalist approach.

⁷Such a theory is implied by Eliezer Schweid in his *Jewish Thought in the 20th Century: An Introduction* (trans. Amnon Hadary; Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1992) 327–33. Schweid places R. Nahman's theory of divine absence between the quasi-Nietzschean pessimism of the Jewish poet Yosef Hayyim Brenner and the positivistic Tolstoyian ideology of A. D. Gordon, two influential thinkers in early twentieth-century Israeli thought. Referring to R. Nahman's stories, Schweid states, "The picture which emerges from his stories is one of unbridled apostasy where demonic depravity reigns the world. The state of '*hester panim*'—the eclipse of God—which is endemic to Exile has deteriorated to a full-blown severance from God. God's presence is nowhere in evidence, not even tangentially. . . . The sovereignty of God is at best a distant dream, a willed vision, a groundless chimera, whereas evil is mighty, palpable and inescapable" (p. 328). I would suggest that Schweid, possibly influenced by Joseph Weiss's studies on R. Nahman's existential persona, is reading too much of Joseph Hayyim Brenner's pessimism into R. Nahman. R. Nahman, unlike Brenner, does claim to resolve the crisis, both existentially as well as mystically. I am, nonetheless, in total agreement with Schweid's juxtaposition of R. Nahman between Brenner and Gordon, making him a model of the modern struggle to come to terms with a world from which God is absent.

arly audience due to its intricate exegetical framework, can offer an authentic Jewish response to the idea of divine absence which challenges the modern seeker of religious meaning.

■ An Explication of R. Nahman

For the most part, classical scholarship on the ideological foundations of hasidism has worked under the assumption that hasidism is preoccupied with the notion of divine immanence.⁸ The Besht's emphasis on God as the "filler of worlds" has been viewed as the signpost for hasidic ideology. In both its mystical formulations and its more faith-oriented presentation, hasidism has often been viewed as a religious ideology founded on uncovering the presence of God in the world. This uncovering is seen as a personal and collective process of redemption. The notion of revealing the divinity hidden in the recesses of nature, however, presupposes the omnipresence of God in the world; God's hiddenness is therefore epistemological rather than ontological.

Although such a principle indeed exists in hasidism,⁹ R. Nahman's philosophy is different. His theory of divine presence and the human experience of it (*devekut*) is based upon overcoming the ontological absence of God depicted in the void that preceded creation in the Lurianic scheme set forth by R. Luria.¹⁰ In order to understand R. Nahman's position on the absence of God, one must first address his reading of the Lurianic concept of *zimzum*. *Zimzum*, or divine contraction, is the kabbalistic solution to the perennial problem of how the finite world could emerge from the infinite God. Even as the Lurianic reading of *zimzum* suggests the creation of a void—a place of divine absence that becomes the space of creation—this absence of God is usually viewed as one stage in a dynamic process whereby the absence of God, or the void, is overcome by a new influx of divine

⁸For some classical articles in English on the social and ideological foundations of hasidism, see Ben Zion Dinur, "The Origins of Hasidism and its Social and Messianic Foundations," in Gershon David Hundert, ed., *Essential Papers in Hasidism: Origins to Present* (New York/London: New York University Press, 1991); Simon Dubnow, "The Beginnings: The Baal Shem Tov and the Center in Podolia," in Hundert, *Essential Papers in Hasidism*, 25–58; Abraham J. Heschel, *The Circle of the Baal Shem Tov* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1985); Louis Jacobs, "Hasidism," *EncJud* 7 (1972) 1403–7; and Gershom Scholem, "Devekut or Communion with God," in idem, *The Messianic Idea in Judaism* (New York: Schocken, 1971) 203–27.

⁹This was particularly true of early Habad hasidism. See Rachel Elior, *The Paradoxical Ascent to God* (Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 1993) 49–78.

¹⁰The importance of the recognition of divine absence has been addressed by scholars of Jewish mysticism. See, for example, Scholem, *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 7–8: "There is no room for mysticism as the link, as the abyss between man and God has not become a fact of the inner consciousness. . . . Mysticism does not deny or overlook the abyss; on the contrary it begins by realizing its existence."

light into creation. While the notion of *zimzum* introduces the possibility of divine absence as only a temporary phase in the dynamic process of creation, R. Nahman focused his attention on this part of the process rather than on its culmination, when the absence is infused with a renewed state of divinity.

While some eastern European Jewish proponents of the *zimzum* theory attempted to theosophize or rationalize divine contraction,¹¹ R. Nahman did not focus on the cosmic movement of God, but on the emotional angst of the one who seeks God's presence. His position emerged slowly as he attempted to integrate the conventional notion of *zimzum* into his radical reading. Initially, he followed the classic kabbalistic view that God creates his own absence in order to allow for the possibility of creation.¹² What is therefore first created is the void, which is then filled with a finite form of divine presence that culminates in human beings, who serve as a bridge between creation and that which preceded it. In R. Nahman's approach, the kabbalistic notion of God's presence in creation does not fully supplant the initial creation of the void.¹³ The void is interpreted as the empirical expe-

¹¹The issue of literal and nonliteral readings of *zimzum* in post-Lurianic Kabbala is central in early hasidism, particularly in Habad hasidism. See, for example, Shneur Zalman of Liady, *Likkutei Torah* (Brooklyn: Kehot, 1979) 104–6; and Aharon ha-Levi of Starosielce, *Sha'arei ha-Yihud ve ha-Emunah* (2 vols.; Jerusalem: Mekkor, 1982) 1. 42a–43b. See also Elior, *Paradoxical Ascent*, 79–91; and Tamar Ross, "Two Interpretations of *Tzimzum*: R. Hayyim of Volozhin and R. Shneur Zalman of Liady," *Mehkarei Yerushalayim* 2 (1982) 152–69 [Hebrew]. For an alternate reading of the use of *zimzum* in postmedieval Jewish mysticism, see Y. Ben-Shlomo, "The Kabbala of the Ari in the Teachings of R. Kook," *Mehkarei Yerushalayim* 10 (1992) 449–57 [Hebrew].

¹²See, for example, R. Hayyim Vital, *Ozrot Hayyim*, part 1: *Mevo She'arim* 1.1.1 and idem, "Sha'ar ha-Kelalim" in *Ez Hayyim* (n. p.: Mekor Hayyim, n. d.) 5a. A systematic appraisal of Lurianic *zimzum*, which may have influenced R. Nahman, can be found in Moshe Hayyim Luzzatto, *One Hundred and Thirty-Eight Openings of Wisdom* (Bnei Brak: n. p., 1992) 58–72 [Hebrew]. See also Isaiah Tishby, *The Doctrine of Evil and the 'Kelippah' in Lurianic Kabbala* (reprinted Jerusalem: Magnes, 1991) 13–20 [Hebrew]; and Scholem, *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 261–64. On Luzzatto's influence on hasidism, see Isaiah Tishby, "Iknot Ramhal be-Mishnat ha-Hasidut," *Zion* 43 (1978) 201–34. For a more traditional rendition of the kabbalistic notion of *zimzum*, see Aryeh Kaplan, *Inner Space* (Jerusalem: Moznaim, 1990) 120–31. This book attempts to introduce major themes in Kabbala, mostly from the Lurianic tradition. It is interesting that in the discussion of *zimzum*, a large part of the chapter is devoted to R. Nahman's reading of *zimzum* and the void.

¹³The notion that the void remains after creation is, as far as I know, R. Nahman's alone. A more conventional view is expressed by Luzzatto (*One Hundred Thirty-Eight Openings*, 66): "The emanated light is called a *rishimu* ['remnant'] of the primordial light. . . . The secret of this remnant is what is called the space of all existence, because it gives [life] to all of that which exists, which the eternal light could not have given. This space is called *halal* ['void']. It is empty of the eternal *eyn sof*, which is the primordial light which existed before." See also Luzzatto's commentary to Vital's *Ozrot Hayyim* in *Ginzei Ramhal* (Bnei Brak: n. p., 1984) 297: "The void (*halal*) is that which is empty of eternity (*bilti takhlit*). The remnant which remains

rience of God's absence that becomes, in R. Nahman's understanding, the heretical notion of faithlessness.¹⁴ Faithlessness is the outcome of giving credence to the observation of a world empty of God; yet R. Nahman apparently could not let go of the very notion that he deemed so dangerous. He was not willing to turn away from the heresy of divine absence by calling it an illusion.¹⁵ Whereas traditional readers of R. Nahman stress that his interpretation of the void is in concert with the cosmic void of creation in the Lurianic scheme, I would argue that R. Nahman had little interest in the ontology of the cosmic void. What interested him was that the void may serve as a foundation for the emotional response to the perception of divine absence in human experience. To complicate matters further, he suggested that the absence of God and the eternal nature of God (as *eyn sof*) are identical vis-à-vis human experience. Both represent the unbridled passion of human emotions and desire that yield spiritual impotence, faithlessness, and heresy, if left unattended.¹⁶ The kabbalistic formu-

is called 'empty air.' [Yet] there is no void without a remnant [of divine light]." The notion of the remnant of light left after the *zimzum* serves as a source for the panentheistic idea in the hasidic reading of Kabbala. R. Nahman suggested that the void or emptiness of God is not supplanted by the divine light (*or yashar*) that is injected subsequently into the void. For more on the source of this remnant of light in Lurianic Kabbala, see Hayyim Vital, *Sha'ar ha-Hakdamot* (Jerusalem: n.p., 1850) 17–23; R. Shlomo b. Hayyim Haikel Eliashuv, *Leshem Shevo ve-Ahlahamah, Hakdamot ve Sha'arim* (Jerusalem: n. p., 1948) 35ff; *Shemen Sasson* no. 2, a commentary of R. Shalom Sharabi's *Nahar Shalom* printed in the Mekor Hayyim edition of the *Ez Hayyim* p. 49c and Jacob b. Hayyim Zemah, *Zohar ha-Raki'a* (Koretz: Kriger, 1785) 23a.

¹⁴The classic Lurianic stance on this is that the product of *zimzum* is the emergence of judgment (*middat ha-din*). See, for example, Hayyim Vital, "Drosh Igulim ve Yosher," in *Ez Hayyim*, 11d. For a scholarly study on this idea in Kabbala, see Mordecai Pachter, "Circles and Lines—The History of an Idea," *Da'at* 18 (1987) 59–90 [Hebrew].

¹⁵Mendel Piekartz argues (*Studies in Bratzlav Hasidism* [Jerusalem: Mosad Bialik, 1972] 21–55) that R. Nahman was infatuated with heresy; after a fire destroyed his house in Bratzlav, R. Nahman decided to settle in Uman, a Ukrainian town known for its Jewish heretics. When he first arrived in Uman he stayed in the house of a well-known member of the Jewish Enlightenment rather than in the residence of the local rabbi. Traditional interpreters explain this strange phenomenon by arguing that R. Nahman intentionally engaged these heretics to redeem the divine sparks embedded in their souls, fulfilling the Lurianic directive of "descent for the sake of ascent." This idea became a central feature in the thought of Sabbatai Zvi, who proclaimed himself messiah in the seventeenth century. For a discussion on the similarities between these two figures, see Yehuda Liebes, "*Ha-Tikkun ha-Kelali* of R. Nahman of Bratzlav and its Sabbatean Links," in idem, *Studies in Jewish Myth and Jewish Messianism* (trans. Batya Stein; Albany: SUNY Press, 1993) 115–48.

¹⁶See, for example, R. Nahman of Cheryn (in his commentary to *Likkutei MoHaRan* entitled *Parpera'ot le Hokhma* [Brooklyn: n. p., 1976] 37a) who comments: "We are forced to state that God removed Himself from that place [that is, the place of the *zimzum*]. In truth, however, in this place there is also divinity since there can be nothing without Him. Rather, godliness is hidden and concealed there so much that it is likened to an 'empty void' in order

lation of the cosmic void reflects R. Nahman's empirical findings, placing him constantly on the verge of faithlessness and despair.¹⁷ Rather than succumbing to the temptation of fatalism, however, R. Nahman saw in the process of creation an antidote for his own situation; human beings can move beyond the void by first recreating and then possessing it, retreating from our own creation as God did in the kabbalistic reading of the biblical account of creation. In such a manner, R. Nahman invited humans to reproduce emotionally the entire creative process and thus to utilize the void, as was the case in creation, as a constructive tool in the search for divine presence.¹⁸

The most explicit and developed statement of the void in R. Nahman's thought appears in *Likkutei MoHaRan* §1.64, where he described his typology of heresy:

Know that there are two types of heresy. There is one heresy which is derived from extraneous wisdom. . . . [The claims of] this heresy may be answered, for they come from extraneous wisdom, brought about by the breaking of the vessels. . . . God can be found there, if one looks for Him and seeks Him out. . . . Therefore it is said, "Know what to answer the heretic" [*m. 'Abot* 2.14]. . . . God is, as it were, inside all the worlds, yet he surrounds them. But there must remain some space between His immanence and His transcendence, for if not, the world

to create a place for the creation." This reading indeed reflects the classical interpretation of all theories of *zimzum*. See, for example, Zemaḥ, *Zohar ha-Raki'a*, 23a–b. In my view, however, it deviates sharply from the way this void is used by R. Nahman in *Likkutei MoHaRan* 79d (§1.64).

¹⁷Although Green and Weiss used R. Nahman's teachings as the basis for their respective psychoanalytic appraisals of his personality, I do not intend to take a similar stance. Rather, I find the spiritual struggle implicit in R. Nahman's teachings as indicative of a Jewish spirituality founded upon the real possibility of unbelief. In my view, his struggle mirrors the spiritual life of Pascal, whose conversion and subsequent spiritual struggle were not deemed by his biographers as psychotic or depressive. See, for example, Romano Guardini, *Pascal for Our Time* (trans. B. Thompson; New York: Herder & Herder, 1966) 45–88; and Jean Mesnard, *Pascal* (trans. Claude and Marcia Abraham; Alabama: University of Alabama Press, 1965).

¹⁸The notion that the affirmation of the void can lead to a renewed sense of religious meaning is strikingly similar to Nietzsche's stance that nihilism can be restorative. See, for example, Karen Leslie Carr, *The Banalization of Nihilism: Twentieth Century Responses to Meaninglessness* (Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 1992); Carr states, "Such questioning [the questioning of truth], however, is a temporary state; from such abysses, from such severe sickness, one returns *newborn*." One requires a more 'delicate taste of joy,' and finds within a second dangerous innocence. Thus we see here confirmation that Nietzsche regarded nihilism as a potentially restorative and redemptive event, something not only useful, but necessary for the renewed experience of the world" (p. 48). Of course, for R. Nahman, restoration as mystical experience arises only through faith. For Nietzsche, according to Carr, the healing quality of nihilism is that it finally liberates man from the "sick" state of dependence and impotence. As is the case with most comparisons between hasidism and existentialism, their common bond is only in their shared assumptions, not in their resolutions.

could not exist. . . . There is [thus] a second type of heresy, made up of wisdom, which is really no wisdom at all. The perplexities and questions of this heresy come from the void (*halal*). They have about them the quality of silence, because no intellect nor language can resolve them. Creation came about through the word. . . . In language there is intellect. . . language defines all things. . . . But in the void which surrounds all worlds and is completely empty, there is no language.¹⁹ . . . Therefore the questions which arise, they are silent.²⁰

In this synopsis of a much more complex text, R. Nahman introduced the basic elements of his reading of the void. The person of faith faces two challenges. The first challenge confronting the one who seeks divine wisdom is the heresy rooted in the finite creation, the product of the breaking of the cosmic vessels in Lurianic Kabbala (*shvirat ha-kelim*). In this heresy, as in the finite world, God exists, and by finding the divine element in the philosophical question one can resolve the crisis of faith. The challenge is to uncover the divine element hidden in the shards of the apparently heretical question, revealing that it is not heresy at all. R. Nahman believed that this type of heresy was not compelling for the seeker of divine truth, but only satisfying for one whose spiritual journey is limited to this finite world. On this, R. Nahman stated, "There is a difference between these [two] questions. There is a question to which one can understand the answer. On this [type] of question the mishna states, 'Know what to answer the heretic' [*m. 'Abot* 2.14]. There is also a question, however, to which it is impossible for a human being to find an answer."²¹ This is the second challenge. Apparently unsatisfied with uncovering the divine in the first question, R. Nahman set for himself a much more formidable task: he sought not only the God in creation—the immanent God—but the transcendent God as well. This search for the transcendent God forced R. Nahman to confront the initial perception of God's absence. The question of the first heretic is resolved by coming to understand the apparent ab-

¹⁹The term "language" here refers to the noncommunicative language of the *Sefer Yezirah*, where the Hebrew letters are viewed as the fabric of the cosmic world. Therefore, R. Nahman suggested that the void is the remnant of divine contraction (*zimzum*) that was not filled with the finite form of God in the supernal worlds. He drew his notion of language in this case from *m. 'Abot* 5.1, "With ten utterances God created the world." On the nature of language in *Sefer Yezirah*, see Ithamar Gruenwald, "Some Critical Notes on the First Part of *Sefer Yezira*," *REJ* 132 (1973) 475–512; and Joseph Dan, *Three Types of Ancient Jewish Mysticism* (Cincinnati: University of Cincinnati Press, 1984) 16–24.

²⁰See R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRa*n (New York: n. p., 1976) 78b–79c. I used portions of Green's translation (*Tormented Master*, 312).

²¹R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRa*n 19d (§1.62). See also 20b (§2.12). For a study on the implications of the "question" in R. Nahman, see Joseph Weiss, "The 'Question' in the Teachings of R. Nahman," in Piekarz, *Studies in Bratzlav Hasidism*, 109–49 [Hebrew].

sence of God as an illusion. The question of the second heretic cannot be resolved rationally.

Throughout history, the dichotomy between the immanent and transcendent God permeates Jewish theology, both rationalist and mystical. For example, the mystics of the Lurianic school have openly stated that the transcendent God, or *eyn sof*, is not their concern.²² One could argue that the void has no ontic status, but is only a psychological or empirical barrier that separates the eternal God (*eyn sof*) from the immanent God of creation. That is, all of creation is divine. The distinction between God and world is only the result of human limitations. Although this may very well be the position of R. Nahman, close readings of his teachings yield another possibility. The anguish and anxiety that permeated his life as well as his discourse suggested that his experiences were not of the absence of God's presence but the presence of God's absence; the void is not a lacuna between the two dimensions of God, but the possibility of the nonexistence of the transcendent God, which makes the immanent God an illusion. This is not to say that R. Nahman came to such a conclusion; his life's work attempted to avert such heresy and disbelief. He began, however, with the assumption that the heretical question must be taken seriously if it is to be overcome. Moreover, only by confronting this question can one achieve an experience of the transcendent God.²³

Whoever contemplates the void not as the absence of divine presence, but the experience of divine absence, is confronted by the second heretic, whose question is rooted in this void. In this case, the human intellect is rendered useless as the question is no longer intellectual but experiential. Regarding this, R. Nahman stated, "When a man follows his intellect and

²²This was not so in the earlier Kabbala. Gershom Scholem (in R. J. Z. Werblowsky, ed., *Origins of the Kabbalah* [trans. Alan Arkush; Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1987] 431) states, "From 1250 onward, a degree of uncertainty existed among kabbalists with regard to such important questions as whether the first *sefirah* itself was not to be considered the transcendent diety, or whether the *sefirot* were to be regarded as identical with the substance of the diety, or merely organs of its manifestation." This was not the case for the Lurianists, for whom *eyn sof* is clearly beyond the scope of human inquiry; see also Daniel Chanan Matt, "Ayin: The Concept of Nothingness in Jewish Mysticism," in Robert K. C. Forman, ed., *The Problem of Pure Consciousness* (New York/Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1990) 121–59; and Moshe Idel, "On the Concept of *Zimzum* in Kabbala and its Research" *Mekhekarei Yerushalayim* 10 (1992) 59–113, esp. 60–68 [Hebrew].

²³R. Nahman's interest in heresy was not limited to the theoretical. Although his desire to settle in Uman at the end of his life is shrouded in mystery, one theory is that he was drawn to the Jewish heretics in the city, with whom he developed an ongoing relationship. For studies that deal with the move to Uman and R. Nahman's relationship to the Maskilim, see Hayyim Lieberman, "Rabbi Nahman Bratslaver and the Maskilim in Uman," *Yivo Annual of Jewish Social Studies* 6 (1951) 287–301; Piekarz, "The Episode of Uman in the Life of R. Nahman of Bratzlav," *Studies In Bratzlav Hasidism*, 21–55 [Hebrew]; and Green, *Tormented Master*, 251–65.

mind he can fall prey to many mistakes and barriers and can come to great evil, God forbid.”²⁴ To conclude from this statement that R. Nahman vied for a retreat to “simple faith” as the only solution to the human epistemic dilemma is, in my view, premature. The challenge of the void poses a particular danger to the spiritual seeker. Yet one’s desire for God should not be destroyed by this ominous challenge; unless one passes through this dark forest, the quest for the transcendent God remains unanswered. R. Nahman stated that the general solution is faith (*’emunah*), but this must be understood practically in terms of what R. Nahman in other places called silence and the primal wordless scream²⁵—two applied methods of attaining the necessary emotional state in order for the language of faith to be constructive.

R. Nahman’s view of faith is complex, and a full treatment of his highly nuanced approach is beyond the scope of this present study. It is important, however, to note that he spoke of two distinct types of faith, the first a “simple” faith, the second a “dialectical” faith. R. Nahman maintained that the first type of faith should be that of everyone except the *zaddik* of the generation, a group that included R. Nahman, one presumes. It is a faith that rejects philosophical speculation and negates the use of reason as the matrix of religious worship.²⁶ R. Nahman strongly argued that the one who adheres to simple faith must discard reason: “Truly, reason ought to be cast aside and all cleverness discarded—God must be worshipped in simplicity.”²⁷ This simple faith is highly antirational, even in the devotional world of hasidic piety. The second type of faith requires interaction with the heretic, a knowledge of philosophy, and thus the constant struggle to overcome the heretical question.²⁸ This second, dialectical type of faith brings forth suffering and anguish; it is the faith of the *zaddik*, for only he can truly overcome the absence of God and reach the experience of the tran-

²⁴R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRan* 19d (§2.12).

²⁵*Ibid.*, 9b–c (§1.8).

²⁶The simple faith of the Hasid is perhaps the faith in the *zaddik* and the ability of the *zaddik*, who exhibits the second type of faith, to redeem him from his spiritual malaise. See R. Nahman’s image (*Likkutei MoHaRan* 80a–81b [§1.65]) of the “master of the garden” (the *zaddik*) who must nurture the “trees outside the garden” (the Hasidim), whom the *zaddik* ultimately brings back to the garden from which they have been exiled. This lesson has been translated and published as a pamphlet by the Breslov Research Institute; see *Garden of the Souls* (trans. Avraham Greenbaum; Monsey, NY: Breslov Research Institute: n.d.). See also R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Sihot ha-Ran* (Jerusalem: Breslav Publishers, 1961) 141.

²⁷R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRan* 15 (§2.5). This battle against reason for the masses and the interaction with reason (*tikkun*) for the *zaddik* is developed in Liebes, “*Ha-Tikkun Ha-Kelali* of R. Nahman of Bratzlav,” 115–51, esp. 124.

²⁸For a discussion of the notion of dialectical faith in R. Nahman see Green, *Tormented Master*, 285–330; and Joseph Dan, *The Hasidic Story: Its History and Development* (Jerusalem: Keter, 1975) 144–71 [Hebrew].

scendent God.²⁹ It appears, however, that the faith presented in R. Naḥman's lessons is a dialectical one and not a simple faith that would retreat from any confrontation with the void. For the adherent of simple faith, the whole exegetical enterprise is largely useless, as is the possibility of experiencing the transcendent God. Hence, the pattern of using the primal scream and prayer, which I shall now address, should open one's consciousness to the new dimension of God's presence beyond God's absence, but this pattern is only relevant for the one who dares to take the road of the dialectic.

In numerous places R. Naḥman stressed that the nonverbal scream has the potential to break through the silence—which is the experiential confrontation with divine absence of God—and thus yield an experience of divine presence.

Sometimes it is that consciousness (*mohin*) and divine everflow (*shefa*) are hidden in the dimension of pregnancy (*ibur*).³⁰ At that time, the human scream is wonderful, whether in prayer or study. . . . This scream is in the place of the scream of the *shekhina*, as if the *shekhina* is screaming. At that point, the [hidden] *mohin* are born [revealed].³¹

²⁹For some examples of R. Naḥman's explicit directions not to become involved with this dialectical faith, see R. Nathan (Sternharz) of Nemerov *Ḥayyei MoHaRan* (Jerusalem: Breslav Publishers, 1976) 48–55; and *Siḥot ha-Ran*. R. Naḥman stated (“Devotion to God,” 175–76): “And he spoke to me about the ways of serving God, which usually entail great suffering. . . . He then said, But this does not mean you, since you always must be joyful.” R. Naḥman himself stated, however, that even the *zaddik* can experience joy once he recognizes that his own suffering is due to his lack of vision (*Likkutei MoHaRan* 80c–d [§1.65]). For a development of the notion of suffering and the tragic fate of the *zaddik* as a necessary component in healing the world, see R. Naḥman of Cheryn, *Parpera'ot le Ḥokhma* 37c on *Likkutei MoHaRan* (§1.65), where the author notes that the lesson in question was delivered just before the death of R. Naḥman's son, Shlomo Efrayim. R. Naḥman apparently felt that his son's suffering was the fate of the *zaddik* who had to perish in order to redeem the world. A more elaborate version of this episode can be found in Aryeh Kaplan, *Until the Mashiach: Rabbi Nachman's Biography, an Annotated Chronology* (ed. David Shapiro; Jerusalem: Breslov Research Institute, 1985) 121–23. According to this source, R. Naḥman's first son, Shlomo Efrayim, was born the spring of 1805 and died the summer of 1806 after contracting tuberculosis. The lesson on the necessity of the suffering of the *zaddik* was said beside his son's deathbed, days before his untimely passing.

³⁰The idea of pregnancy (*ibur*) in Lurianic Kabbala is a central principle in the process of *tikkun*. There are three stages of cosmic pregnancy, and each serves as a gestation period for the broken fragments of the supernal world; these are born as “new” stages of consciousness (*mohin*) and then nurtured (*yenika*) until they reach maturation. See, for example, Vital, “Sha'ar ha-Kelalim,” in *Ez Ḥayyim*, 9c, 10a; and idem, *Mevo She'arim* 12a–b (§2.3.2). See also R. Jacob Ḥayyim Zemah's gloss to *Mevo She'arim* 12a (§2.3.2) no. 2. For a scholarly discussion on the notion of pregnancy in Lurianic Kabbala, see Mordecai Pachter, “Smallness and Greatness in Lurianic Kabbala,” *Mekhkarei Yerushalayim* 10 (1992) 171–210 [Hebrew].

³¹R. Naḥman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRan* 30b (§1.21). See also 111b (§1.198): “When one screams to God, they say to him ‘go forward,’ as it is written (Exod 14:15), ‘then the Lord said to Moses, Why do you cry out to me? Tell the Israelites to go forward.’” Interestingly,

The scream serves as a midwife, as it were, which, reflecting the exilic character of the *shekhina*, yields a new level of consciousness. This new *moḥin* diminishes the alienation of the worshipper by revealing the divine overflow (*shefa*).

In a complex discussion concerning the *makkifim* ("hovering light"),³² which R. Nahman defined as a level of consciousness hovering outside the realm of human experience, he stated:

The fundamental question [which concerns us] is how do we birth this consciousness (*moḥin*) from its concealed state? Afterward, when it emerges, how can we integrate the *makkifim* ["external consciousness"] inside [our consciousness]? How this is accomplished has already been well explained. That is, by way of the scream of Torah study and prayer we can birth this consciousness from its concealed place. By means of the sanctity of the seven lights of the Temple menorah which represent the sanctification of our eyes by not gazing upon forbidden things; also by sanctifying the mouth, the nose and the ears we can draw these *makkifim* inside.³³

In this particular case, the scream is not wordless but rather a mode of verbal expression that allows the words of study or prayer to give birth to a new state of consciousness. This then becomes integrated into the individual only to introduce new *makkifim*, which then must be integrated as well.

In another instance, the scream does not contain words but opens up the possibility *for* words. Discussing the trial of sexual desire, which faces each individual, R. Nahman stated:

R. Nahman transformed the apparently negative implications of Moses' scream in the biblical narrative to something that enables one to "go forward," that is, to give birth to consciousness (*moḥin*) and thus pray. For other examples of this, see R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRan* 32d (§1.22) 50d (§1.36) 89d–90b (§1.75).

³²R. Nahman's use of *makkifim* is quite complex; in Lurianic Kabbala this term generally refers to light that first retreated from vessels of creation before they shattered and then descended into the depths of the void. These lights remain undamaged and subsequently are utilized in the process of *tikkun* by slowly entering and exiting the broken vessel, each time building the vessel until it will be able to sustain a total integration of the light. R. Nahman used this concept to illuminate the slow development of human consciousness. Green states (*Tormented Master*, 302–4) that the term *makkifim* in R. Nahman's thought serves as the core of his dialectical faith as opposed to simple faith. In Lurianic Kabbala the "dialectical" phenomenon in the cosmic process of *tikkun* can be found in *Etz Hayyim* Palace 1, Palace of *Adam Kadmon*, Seventh Gate, the Gate of *Mate ve lo Mate*, 24–30. R. Nahman used this motif explicitly in one instance in *Likkutei MoHaRan* (36d [§1.24]), where he stressed the impossibility of apprehending the light of *eyn sof*, even by means of the dialectical process of *mate be lo mate* except via *simḥa* ("joyousness").

³³*Ibid.*, 31d (§1.21).

The principle test that man is confronted with is the test of sexual desire. This [desire] is embodied in the seventy nations, which is embodied in the notion of *other* (*ʿaḥer*), *another God*. When one screams, as it is written, “*My soul cries for You, O God*” (Ps 42:1), one must scream seventy times, not less [corresponding to the seventy nations].³⁴ Then the secrets of the Torah will be open to him and the hidden will be revealed to him, new souls and Torah will be born. That [new] Torah is embodied in the totality of the souls of Israel. It will reveal the faces of Torah which were, until now, concealed in the extraneous matter (*kelippot*).³⁵

In each of the three cases cited, the scream discloses new possibilities. In the second text, a scream without words breaks apart the silence, which is represented as both the root of sexual desire and idolatry. In the previous text, the use of the word *ʿaḥer*—literally, “other”—appears to have a double meaning. As R. Naḥman indicated, it implies either “another God” or idolatry. It is also, however, the name given to the talmudic heretic R. Elisha b. Avuiah, whose statement, “there is no judge and there is no justice,”³⁶ resounds with the heresy of divine absence with which R. Naḥman grappled throughout his teaching. According to my reading of R. Naḥman, Elisha b. Avuiah’s mistake was not in his perception of the absence of God, but in his inability to complete the creative process beginning—but not ending—with *zimzum* in order to apprehend the transcendent nature of God beyond the absence. The heretical nature of this tannaitic sage is that he initiated a process that he did not complete. Perhaps the silence of divine absence R. Naḥman likened to the question of the second heretic discussed earlier is the very root of the heresy of the rabbinic sage and is transcended through the scream, or the voice that precedes creation, the scream that enables the words of creation to emerge. As the world is created through *zimzum* and this is followed by the “ten utterances” (*m. ʿAbot* 1:5), human *zimzum* is accomplished by the scream, which is followed by words of study and prayer. The scream brings one past the darkness, through the void to the presence of God as creator by giving birth to a new state of consciousness, moving from the wordless to the word.³⁷ This scream is

³⁴For R. Naḥman, the seventy nations are synonymous with idolatry and the force of evil. See, for example, *ibid.*, 13a (§1.10) where the Gentile as idol worshipper is likened to the “power of death” in *Gen. R.* 9.

³⁵R. Naḥman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRan* 50d–51a (§1.36); my italics. This statement is not part of the original lesson, but a later addition by the editor. These additions, most of which are statements made by R. Naḥman himself, are not uncommon in *Likkutei MoHaRan*. See Weiss, *Studies in Bratzlav Hasidism*, 251–77.

³⁶b. *Ber.* 15b.

³⁷In another passage (*Likkutei MoHaRan* 9b–c [§1.8]), R. Naḥman likened the creative process to the breath (*ruah*) of God, again an illusion to a sound that has no linguistic formu-

intended to force the individual to confront divine absence and to produce a way beyond that absence.³⁸ In typical hasidic style, R. Nahman argued that one must confront the cosmic emptiness with one's own emptiness, with the very fabric of the void within oneself.³⁹ Yet this void is not an intrinsic part of the individual but must be created by the person, just as the void of the *zimzum* was created by God. Through silence and the wordless scream—through that which comes before prayer and through prayer itself—R. Nahman believed that he could delve into the void and emerge unscathed. The mechanics of this process must now be addressed.

In *Likkutei MoHaRan* 1.5, R. Nahman addressed this issue from a slightly different perspective. The wordless scream discussed above becomes the image of thunder, which empties the heart of insincerity—literally, crookedness—in order to experience joy.

The fundamental place of joy is in the heart, as it is written (Ps 4:8), "You put joy into my heart." It is impossible for the heart to be joyous until it removes the crookedness which is in the heart; that it should be a "straight heart" (*yishrei lev*). At that point he will merit joy, as it is written (Ps 97:12), "O you righteous [straight hearted], rejoice in the Lord." The crookedness in the heart is removed by thunder as it says in Talmud Berakhot (59b), "Thunder was not created except to remove crookedness from the heart." Thunder corresponds to the voice which comes forth strongly in prayer. From this [strong voice] thunder is created.⁴⁰

This text likens the heavenly voice of thunder which, as the talmudic passage suggests, causes the heart to become straight by arousing one to fear the power of God, to the voice that emerges in prayer. The individual, by being attentive to his or her own voice—not the words of prayer, but the power of the voice itself—enables the heart to become "straight" and thus experiences joy (*simḥa*). Like the primal scream discussed earlier, the voice of prayer in this passage empties the heart. The emptying of the heart enables one to be joyous; it allows one's heart and mind to interact in order to filter reason through the chambers of the heart, the place of faith, and

lation: "How great is the groan and sigh of a Jew, for this [causes] the perfection of his deficiencies. By means of the aspect of breath, which is the spirit of life, the world was created. . . . The newness of the world comes about through breath [*ruaḥ*, meaning both breath and spirit]." This breath or spirit is depicted here as a sigh or groan that shares the nonlinguistic character of the scream that precedes linguistic prayer.

³⁸See for example in Yehudit Kook, *R. Nahman of Bratzlav: Studies in His Writings* (Jerusalem: Mosad Y. L. Girsh, 1973) 169–75 [Hebrew].

³⁹This idea is strikingly similar to Carl G. Jung's notion of the "shadow" or the "dark self." See his *Psychology and Religion* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1938) 93–95; and idem, *Man and His Symbols* (New York: Doubleday, 1964) 168–76.

⁴⁰R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRan* 5c (§1.5).

thus to experience the true nature of the *mitzvot*, the commandments. I must now develop this idea further in order to view how R. Nahman continued to deepen his reading of *zimzum* as a human act that opens the possibility for the experience of the transcendent God.

In *Likkutei MoHaRan* 1.49, R. Nahman began a lengthy discussion on prayer with what seems to be a reiteration of his view of *zimzum*. There are, however, subtle nuances worth noting. R. Nahman stated that the concept of *eyn sof* (God as infinite) is a prerequisite for creation, yet cannot sustain creation as such. If the purpose of creation is, as R. Nahman put it, “to reveal the glory of God,” this recognition of God can only occur through the fragmentation of worlds that can hold attributes of God’s finite presence.⁴¹ This framework of “worlds and attributes” is, by definition, antithetical to God as eternal (*eyn sof*). In this case, the void (*halal*) is not the place empty of God but a place so full of God that God cannot be recognized by humans. The ontic character of *zimzum* as presented by the Lurianic school is now interpreted phenomenologically. God’s absence and God’s eternal presence become identical.⁴²

The process of this act of creation is now read into the act of prayer. Prayer must be preceded by a desire for God. Yearning for God is viewed as an existential response to the experience of God’s absence.

From the grandeur of the unbridled desire in the heart of a Jew which reaches to the eternal nature of God (*eyn sof*), it would not be possible to perform any act of devotion and thus one would be unable to reveal any positive attribute (*middah*). From the grandeur of this pure heart, it is not possible to do anything! This can be likened to the fact that in the beginning of the creative process, there was no room for creation because everything was eternal (*eyn sof*). The creation of the world is the creation of attributes (*middot*). Therefore, it is necessary for a person to contract (limit) the great unbridled desire in his heart which is *eyn sof*, in order to serve God according to gradations and attributes

⁴¹Ibid., 57a (§1.49). “The fundamental purpose of creation is to reveal God’s kingship. This is impossible without the creation of worlds [fragmentation] for there is no King without a people. Therefore, *zimzum* was necessary to [create] the empty void, to create a place for the worlds in order to reveal his kingship” (ibid., 57c [§1.49]). This is a classic definition of the purpose of creation. R. Nahman’s innovation emerged when he likened the eternal nature of God to the unbridled emotions of the heart, and the *zimzum* to the human limitation of those emotions, which creates a void and thus desire in the heart.

⁴²For a discussion of the ontic character of the Lurianic system, see Karl Erich Grozinger, “Principles and Aims in Lurianic Cosmology,” *Mekhkarei Yerushalayim* 10 (1992) 37–46 [Hebrew]. R. Nahman’s reading of *zimzum* here is less psychological and more phenomenological in that his concern is how *zimzum*, as the absence of God, serve as a foundation for one’s perception of the external world. His phenomenological reading retains the ontic character of *zimzum* and uses it to legitimate both his vision of a world without God and his belief in a world full of God.

(*middot*). . . . When one limits the light in one's heart, an empty void remains. . . . It is in that void where good attributes are revealed. They are the secret of the creation of worlds in the divine void (of God).⁴³

This reading appears to be based on the oft-quoted rabbinic dictum that prayer is the service of the heart. Here R. Nahman suggested that the heart before prayer is like God before creation. It is the place of unbridled emotions incapable of sustaining any form and thus potentially very destructive. It is also filled with unbridled desire yet devoid of yearning since, like the *eyn sof*, it contains no distinction and thus has nothing to yearn for.⁴⁴ R. Nahman suggested that prayer, like creation, must be preceded by *zimzum*, that is, an emptiness in the heart, which will house the human desire to pray. Invoking Ps 109:22, "My heart is empty (*halal*) within me,"⁴⁵ R. Nahman stated, "Prayer of the heart is likened to the revelation of God's kingdom [that is, the purpose of creation], from within the empty void, into the divine attributes and the worlds."⁴⁶ One must create the void of divine absence in one's own heart in order for prayer to be effectual, just as God created his absence in order to make way for his finite presence.

What must be avoided are the two opposite poles which pose the same danger. First, one must not allow the emotions embedded in one's heart to go unattended, thus avoiding confrontations of divine absence. This is the

⁴³R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRan* 57c (§1.49).

⁴⁴This idea reflects a similar distinction which Paul Tillich made in his discussion on the nature of the philosopher (*Biblical Religion and the Search for Ultimate Reality* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1955] 11, 12): "We are a mixture of being and non-being. This is precisely what is meant when we say we are finite. It is man in his finitude who asks the question of being. He who is infinite does not ask the question of being, for, as infinite, he has the complete power of being. He is identical with it; he is God. And a being which does not realize that it is finite (and in our actual experience that is every being except man) cannot ask, because it cannot go beyond itself and its limits." Echoing Heidegger, Tillich argued that the notion of nonbeing is the fundamental principle for philosophy (what Heidegger called "thinking" [*Denken*]). R. Nahman suggested that the void—perhaps his confrontation with nonbeing—is the necessary prerequisite for an experience of the transcendent God.

⁴⁵R. Nahman used this verse in another context which corresponds to the present discussion. In *Likkutei MoHaRan* 6b (§1.6) he develops his notion of repentance as the transformation from anger to passive submission: "The fundamental aspect of repentance is that one should hear an embarrassing [remark] and remain silent." Anger is likened to the blood in the left side of the heart (*gevurah*), which is the seat of the evil inclination. The reaction of anger is then the reaction of the evil inclination. "The fixing for this is to turn anger (*dam*, literally 'blood') to submission (*dom*, 'silence')." (6d [§1.6]). Thus the heart is emptied of the blood and left silent or vacant. At this juncture R. Nahman again invoked the verse in Psalms, "My heart is empty within me" (109:22), to illustrate the success of repentance in destroying the evil inclination in the heart. Although in this case the emptiness is not the absence of God but the absence of anger, the emptiness in the heart is still seen as constructive.

⁴⁶R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRan* 6b (§1.6).

realm of *eyn sof* where creation, prayer and divine service (*‘avodah*) are impossible. Second, one must avoid only confronting the emptiness and not completing the creative process by actually elevating the yearning for God in prayer. The first danger will lead to antinomian heresy in that one will never be able to justify the performance of *miẓvot* since one lacks the proper yearning to find God.⁴⁷ The second danger will yield to fatalism: the individual will become overcome by the absence, seeing no possibility of redemption, and thus will be trapped in the snares of the second heretic. Either inaction or incomplete action represents the two dangers that confront the second seeker. When the unbridled eternal nature in the human heart is not confined and directed or when the *zimzum*, which creates the potential for God’s presence, does not look to a renewed flow of divine presence, the individual confronts the second form of heresy, which cannot be resolved by way of reason.

How, then, does one overcome this confrontation with the void, which appears here as a necessary step in the creative process as well as the initial prerequisite for prayer? In *Likkutei MoHaRan* 2.12, R. Nahman began his discussion on doubt by defining the place of doubt as rooted in the “closed utterance” (*ma’amar satum*) that preceded creation.

After (it has been determined that) everything was created for the glory of God, it is found that God is the root of all of creation. All that God created he created for (the revelation) of His glory. It follows that the glory of God is the root (*telos*)⁴⁸ of all of creation. Even though it is all (rooted) in the One, creation (is divided) into parts. Each part has its own (way of manifesting) a particular dimension of his glory, which is its source. This is the meaning of the mishnah in *‘Abot* (5.1), “In ten

⁴⁷The issue of antinomianism is complex and quite subtle in hasidic thought. In this case, I have suggested that for R. Nahman creating the void in one’s own heart allows one to experience the absence of God and thus to yearn for God’s presence. This implies that without that action the individual will conclude that he or she and God are truly one. Thus, any action will be God’s will. Although R. Nahman himself never reached such a conclusion, it was apparently of primary concern. For a discussion of the possible connections between Bratzlav hasidism and the Sabbatean heresy, see Leibes, “*Ha-Tikkun Ha-Kelali* of R. Nahman of Bratzlav,” esp. pp. 128–50. See also Green, *Tormented Master*, 91. For a more general discussion, see Rivka Schatz-Uffenheimer, *Quietistic Elements in Eighteenth Century Hasidic Thought* (Jerusalem: Magnes, 1968) 54–77 [Hebrew]; Scholem, *The Messianic Idea in Judaism*, 78–142; and Shaul Magid, “Hasidism in Transition: The Hasidic Ideology of R. Gershon Henoch of Radzin in Light of Medieval Jewish Philosophy and Kabbala” (Ph.D. diss., Brandeis University, 1994) 474–523.

⁴⁸My rendering of the Hebrew term *shoresh* (literally, “root” or “source”) as *telos* in this case follows the logic of R. Nahman’s argument. Earlier he suggested that the purpose of creation is the revelation of God’s kingship. Here he used the term *kavod* (“glory”) instead of *malkhut* (“kingship”). Similarly, in this instance I believe that he used *shoresh* to mean purpose or *telos*.

utterances the world was created.” He could have created the world with one utterance. In order to make reward and punishment possible, however, he created it with ten utterances. Each utterance contains its own particular dimension of (God’s) glory.⁴⁹

In kabbalistic jargon, the closed utterance is the root of the ten utterances that created the world, an idea originally expressed in *m. ’Abot* 5.1.⁵⁰ According to Lurianic Kabbala, the closed utterance is rooted in the world of creation where distinction has yet to take place.⁵¹ This closed utterance gives birth to the ten fragmented utterances with which God created the world. *Mizvot*, human actions, or words of human speech (*dibur*), can serve as catalysts for humans to maintain a relationship with the utterances, or supernal spheres, which connect the finite with the infinite. Words, however, that are the product of creation within the void of God—words, however, that are by definition the product of creation, which fill the void of God—cannot overcome the heresy that is rooted in the void itself. This challenge can only be met by an expression that is wordless—for R. Nahman, the primal scream or silence that is the ultimate expression of faith. The cosmic closed utterance in the process of creation is thus likened to the nonverbal or preverbal state of human expression. Ironically, speech, whether Torah study or prayer, which in the realm of God’s finite presence connects one to God as an answer to his infinite absence, leads to a verification of divine absence. For R. Nahman the utterance of words (*dibur*), being rooted in the world of creation where the fragmentation of the divine has already taken place, poses a challenge to the spiritual seeker; thus, if human speech is not connected back to its source by subsequent words of prayer, fatalism and faithlessness result. The words of prayer alone are not enough to achieve this goal, however. Words diffuse the initial expression of the soul and can only be productive if they remain rooted in the soul even after they are spoken. Thus, the words of prayer complete a circle that begins with the wordless expression of the soul responding to the realization of divine absence.⁵²

⁴⁹R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRa* 12d–20a (§2.12).

⁵⁰For an interesting and somewhat provocative kabbalistic and hasidic reading of this mishnah, see R. Yizhak Isaac Yehuda Yehiel Safran of Kamarno, *Nozar Hessed* (1855; reprinted Jerusalem: n. p., 1982) 80–81.

⁵¹The notion of the closed utterance as the aspect of the infinite dimension of God that is present but undetectable in the created world is not uncommon in hasidic thought. See, for example, R. Shnuer Zalman of Laidy, *Torah Or* (Brooklyn: Kehot, 1975) 91b–c. In this text the “closed utterance” is termed “closed consciousness” (*moḥin satum*).

⁵²See R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Likkutei MoHaRa* 80b–c (§1.65). R. Nahman apparently based his ideas on *Sefer Yezirah* 1.7 (Jerusalem: Levin Epstein, 1965) 28a: “Their end is unified with their beginning and their beginning is unified with their end.” See Moses Nahmanides’ commentary on that statement; he illuminates the circular nature of the cosmic order in rela-

To overcome divine absence, one must reach beyond creation by creating the abyss in oneself through emotional *zimzum* and then retreat from the realm of divine absence that entices the person of faith with the unresolvable philosophical question. R. Nahman's retreat is not a denial of the experiential confrontation with the absence of God. Rather, it is a stark affirmation of it. This affirmation requires a retreat from finitude to the moment before creation, to relive the *zimzum*, confront the absence that is the product of *zimzum*, and then utilize the void to overcome the second heresy which entices humans to solve its speculative question by using the tools of the finite nature of God. Thus, without denying the existential reality of divine absence, R. Nahman attempted to lead his readers through the winding alleys of his own skeptical soul only to arrive at the iron gate where God is truly absent; in this very confrontation with God's absence, one can locate the key to enter into the palace of God's eternal presence.

In summary, R. Nahman suggested an innovative reading of Lurianic *zimzum* which froze the process of contraction and emanation in order to posit a phenomenological reading of the void. As stated earlier, whether R. Nahman held that this void has any ontological status is not central in his argument. He had little interest in building a cosmology and used the Zoharic/Lurianic model only as it served his existential and phenomenological needs. For R. Nahman, the void exists because humans experience it. The question is then not whether it really exists or is just an illusion resulting from our human limitations. R. Nahman showed little patience for either ontology or epistemology. He sought to resolve the empirical absence of God in order to avoid the heresy that he felt threatens the one who adopts his theory of dialectical faith. Working within the framework of correlation between the supernal world and the mundane world that emerged in the Kabbala of Gerona in the thirteenth century, R. Nahman used the *zimzum* theory as a model for resolving the experience of divine absence in the heart and mind of the one who intently seeks God's presence.

■ R. Nahman and Modern Philosophy

As stated at the outset, R. Nahman's concerns are surprisingly relevant and reflect the crisis of modern persons. In the words of Gershom Scholem, "The void is the abyss, the chasm or the crack which opens up in all that exists. This is the experience of modern man, surpassingly well depicted in

tion to the system of the *sefirot*. R. Nahman took this notion and applied it to the words of prayer: "When one stands on the last word of his prayer, he should still be on the first word of his prayer. In that way he can complete his entire prayer without separating from the first letter of his prayer." The danger of words is that they threaten the closed and holistic nature of the pristine expression of the soul. Thus, the one who speaks must be certain that the words do not become linear and diffuse the initial intent of the soul's yearning.

all its desolation by Kafka, for whom nothing has remained of God but the void—in Kafka's sense, to be sure, the void of God."⁵³ The implications of the *zimzum* theory as explicated by R. Nahman and reiterated by both Scholem and Martin Buber pose a challenge to the Jewish thinker not dissimilar from the existentialist grappling with the assertion that God is dead.⁵⁴ Buber, unlike Scholem, attempted to make a connection between hasidism and existentialism. For Buber, hasidism was "enveloped by the abyss," yet differed from Nietzschean existentialism in that hasidism offered a solution—the redemptive nature of history.⁵⁵ Thus, if R. Nahman's discussion were placed in the context of modern solutions to the problem of the abyss and the absence of God, his ideas are similar to those of theistic existentialists such as Blaise Pascal, Gabriel Marcel, Paul Tillich, and, of course, Søren Kierkegaard, and not Friedrich Nietzsche, Jean-Paul Sartre, and Albert Camus.⁵⁶ In the following pages, I shall initiate such a comparison in the hope that it will inspire others to attempt to draw R. Nahman's message out of its intricate exegetical framework and place it

⁵³Gershom Scholem, "Reflections on Jewish Theology," in W. J. Donnhauser, ed., *On Jews and Judaism in Crisis* (New York: Schocken, 1976) 282. Such an assertion resonates in existential thought from Pascal through Heidegger. Scholem's statement, however, is particularly relevant to the present discussion in that it serves as the conclusion of his discussion on kabbalistic interpretations of creation (*zimzum*). As discussed earlier, *zimzum* is the basis of R. Nahman's affirmation of the void as well as his solution against the heresy that may result from such an assertion. Scholem states, "The universe of space and time, this living process we call Creation, appeared to the kabbalists to be intelligible only if it constituted an act of God's renunciation in which He sets Himself a limit. Creation out of nothing, from the void, could be nothing other than creation of the void, that is, of the possibility of thinking of anything that was not God" (p. 282). Without reference to R. Nahman, whom Scholem respected as a creative hasidic thinker but not as a kabbalist, Scholem seems to have discovered the very foundation of R. Nahman's position.

⁵⁴For the most recent discussion on Scholem and Buber's dialogue on Hasidism, see Jerome Gellman, *The Fear, the Trembling, and the Fire: Kierkegaard and Hasidic Masters on the Binding of Isaac* (New York/London: Lanham, University Press of America, 1994) xiv–xxi. Gellman's work reflects many of the issues I addressed in this article.

⁵⁵See Martin Buber, *The Legends of the Baal Shem Tov* (New York: Schocken, 1969) 69–70: "All things were enveloped by the abyss, and yet the whole abyss was between each thing and the other. None could cross over to the other, indeed none could see the other, for the abyss was between them." As with Scholem's writing, this appears to be a direct reference to R. Nahman, stated in the larger context of early hasidism. Although many early hasidic writings point to this assertion, I have not found the sophisticated and intricate treatment of the problem and its solution in texts other than R. Nahman's *Likkutei MoHaRan*. See also Buber, *Tales of Rabbi Nahman* (trans. Maurice Friedman; New Jersey: Humanities, 1988) 3–17; and idem, "Judaism and Civilization," in idem, *On Judaism* (New York: Schocken, 1967) 194. This issue has also been discussed in Laurence J. Silberstein, *Martin Buber's Social and Religious Thought* (New York: New York University Press, 1989) 50–56.

⁵⁶For a brief overview of some of these figures, see Padovano, *The Estranged God*; and Roberts, *Existentialism and Religious Belief*.

against the more speculative and theologically sophisticated theories of modern theistic thought.

The relationship between faith and reason poses a complex problem in R. Nahman's thinking.⁵⁷ While R. Nahman initially viewed faith as the matrix of religious worship and reason as the "evil inclination" that draws one toward heresy, he also nuanced the concepts.⁵⁸ R. Nahman was a man of faith, but also a man forever enticed by reason. As Arthur Green has noted, R. Nahman was a hasidic master with a complex dialectical personality, and his submission to faith never solved his infatuation with reason.⁵⁹ Thus, faith should not be viewed as the solution to a problem, but as the unfolding of the divine mystery. Gabriel Marcel's distinction between "problem" and "mystery" may shed light on my claim regarding R. Nahman's dialectical faith. Marcel states, "A problem is something which I meet, which I find complete before me, but which I can therefore lay siege to and reduce. A mystery is something in which I myself am involved."⁶⁰ For Marcel, the mystery by definition cannot be resolved precisely because a person can never be fully objective about it. Marcel's distinction between mystery and problem resonates in R. Nahman's dialectical faith. R. Nahman stressed that the process of emotional *zimzum*, which leads from wordless scream to prayer and subsequently the overcoming of divine absence, is a dynamic process requiring constant activity. His notion of *makkifim* as well as his innovative approach to repentance⁶¹ support his view that faith is not

⁵⁷For a thoughtful discussion of this issue see, Green, *Tormented Master*, 275–336.

⁵⁸In my view, the Bratzlav school has minimized the dialectical nature of his thought. For example, R. Nahman's apparent tirade against rationalist medieval philosophy from Sa'adia Ga'on through Gersonides is viewed as his explicit rejection of the whole medieval Jewish philosophical tradition. Although that may be the case, his teachings, only a small portion of which I discussed in this article, exhibit a far more complex picture. This picture yielded a creative and innovative solution to a problem that faith, in its pristine simplistic form, could not cure. For his critique of rationalism, see R. Nathan (Sternharz) of Nemerov, *Hayyei MoHaRan* 2.18d–21b and R. Nahman of Bratzlav, *Sihot ha-Ran*, 36 (§32).

⁵⁹R. Nahman's dialectical thinking emerges numerous times in his teachings. See, for example *Likkutei MoHaRan* 7a (§1.6): "When a person wants to go in the way of repentance, he must be an expert in halakhah. He must be an expert in two aspects—that is, an expert in 'going' (*raẓo*) and an expert in 'coming' (*shov*). The halakhic system becomes a dynamic process that demands an ability to be in constant spiritual motion. This results in the elevation of the one's consciousness to the realization of the divine." See *Zohar* 2.213b and 3.71.

⁶⁰See Gabriel Marcel, *Being and Having* (London: Dacre, 1949) 100. See also idem, "On the Ontological Mystery," in idem, *The Philosophy of Existentialism* (1956; reprinted New York: Citadel, 1962) 19: "A mystery is a problem which encroaches upon its own data, invading them, as it were, and thereby transcending itself as a simple problem."

⁶¹For R. Nahman, repentance is dynamic in that it always yields the need for further repentance. It is the process of human transformation whereby the individual, having achieved a new consciousness through repentance, looks back on his or her first act of repentance and, from his more elevated place, needs to repent on his initial act of repentance. This process

the solution to the problem of divine absence but the affirmation of the ontological mystery of divine presence. Just as Marcel was not interested in constructing a fundamental ontology and had little interest in the question of Being outside of its relationship to humans,⁶² R. Nahman had little interest in kabbalistic theosophy or rooting his existential dilemma in the ontic character of classical Kabbala.⁶³ Marcel reflected R. Nahman's position when he argued that reason limits one's access to mystery and thus one's apprehension of absolute knowledge. He stated,

I firmly believe that scientific truth is in no sense—not even in the most critically real sense—the measure of the real. On the other hand, it is not true to say that science is only an empty formalism; rather, it

continues indefinitely. See *Likkutei MoHaRan* 6d (§1.6c): “Even if a person knows himself that he achieved a complete repentance, he needs to repent on his first repentance. Initially when he repented, he did it according to his understanding. Afterward, when he did repent and thus achieved a higher apprehension of God, it will be found that, according to his understanding now, his initial understanding was mundane. Therefore, he must repent on his initial understanding.”

⁶²See Ralph Harper, *On Presence: Variations and Reflections* (Philadelphia: Trinity, 1991) 39–54. Harper draws an important distinction between the early Heidegger and Marcel, seeing Marcel as a bridge between Heidegger and Buber. The introduction of Buber to Harper's discussion on Marcel strengthens comparison between Marcel and R. Nahman. Buber's earliest works on hasidism focused on R. Nahman of Bratzlav with whom Buber shared a common journey. See Buber's *Tales of Rabbi Nahman*.

⁶³This describes the general attitude of hasidism toward Kabbala, and is even more pronounced in R. Nahman. See, for example, Rachel Elior, “Hasidism—Historical Continuity and Spiritual Change,” in Peter Schäfer and Joseph Dan, eds., *Gershom Scholem's Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism: 50 Years Later* (Tübingen: Mohr, 1994) 318: “Hasidic doctrine did not intend to create a new layer of theosophy in order to decipher the subtleties of the divine cosmology. Rather, it sought to present a *comprehensive dialectical worldview* which would bridge between the divine processes described in Lurianic Kabbala and man's consciousness and his thinking process.” Even though Elior attempts to defend Scholem's thesis that hasidism did not offer an “original” kabbalistic doctrine, I believe her point can be taken out of its formal polemical context. If Elior could make this argument for a more theosophically oriented hasidism such as Habad, it would only strengthen such a claim regarding R. Nahman. Traditional Bratzlav readings of *Likkutei MoHaRan*, beginning with its author R. Nathan of Nemerov, argue that Kabbala was the backbone of R. Nahman's thought. For example, see “Introduction to *Sifre Likkutei MoHaRan*,” in *Likkutei MoHaRan* 5b: “All the writings of the Ari, may his memory be blessed [R. Isaac Luria, a sixteenth century Kabbalist from Safed], the *Zohar*, the *Tikkunim* and all of the holy Kabbala. All of them are included in this holy work [*Likkutei MoHaRan*]. Every lesson is directed toward a particular mitzvah and chapter in [R. Isaac Luria's] *Ez Hayyim*.” This may indeed be the case. R. Nahman's personalist approach, however, does not contribute to the kabbalistic system of Luria, and he does not require his reader to know intimately the kabbalistic system from which he works. In this light Buber's position that hasidism “overcame” the Kabbala by transforming it into a source for the encounter between the human and divine may be useful. See Martin Buber, “Spirit and Body of the Hasidic Movement,” in idem, *Origin and Meaning of Hasidism*, 121–25 and idem, “The Faith of Judaism,” 13.

is such only if we arbitrarily isolate scientific findings from the spiritual activity which has engendered them. Science is relative to the spiritual activity which produces it, and it is a fallacy to see in the world considered as reified science a whole sufficient unto itself.⁶⁴

In both Marcel's and R. Nahman's dialectical faith, reason cannot answer the need of the seeker of presence, but neither can it be abandoned. For R. Nahman, the one who abandons reason is the carrier of simple faith, which cannot yield an experience of presence that lies beyond divine absence. For Marcel, reason or science gives the transcendent—the infinite—a place in the finite and thus opens the possibility for an experience of the infinite.⁶⁵ Both thinkers maintain a dialectical relationship with reason, each arguing—or, in R. Nahman's case, implying—that reason cannot define presence but cannot be abandoned for the sake of presence.

A similar ambivalence regarding reason can be found in Pascal's *Pensées*. Pascal drew an important distinction between reason and Reason, between the use of the mind and heart to acquire knowledge and the claim of Logic as certainty. For Pascal, reason is the handmaiden of faith, useful and adequate as long as it knows its limits. "Reasons, seen from afar, appear to limit our view; but when they are reached, we begin to see beyond."⁶⁶ Although Pascal was critical of a religion based on Reason, he understood that reason plays an important dialectical role in the apprehension of religious Truth.⁶⁷ With regard to R. Nahman's "simple faith," it appears that reason plays only a negative role and thus would fall outside of Pascal's claim. In R. Nahman's dialectical faith, however, reason—depicted as the experience of the absence of God—is represented by the second heretic, the one who is rooted in the void and poses the unanswerable question to the seeker of divine presence. In this case, reason cannot be avoided but must be confronted and only then overcome. This attitude is reflected in Pascal, who spoke of the proponents of theories of religious truth that offer "proofs of God": "But for those in whom this light is extinguished, and in whom we purpose to rekindle it, persons destitute of faith and grace, who, seeking

⁶⁴Gabriel Marcel, *Philosophical Fragments 1909–1914* (trans. Lionel A. Blain; Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1965) 41.

⁶⁵Gabriel Marcel, *The Mystery of Being* (trans. Rene Hague; 2 vols.; Chicago: Regency, 1950) 46: "Not only does the word 'transcendent' *not* mean 'transcending experience,' but on the contrary there must be a possibility of having an experience *of* the transcendent as such, and unless the possibility exists the word can have no meaning." The finite or empirical world gets its life from the infinite, he explained. "In other words, if there is anything real in the finite, it will be infinite; it is from the infinite that the finite gets the little reality it possess, by itself, it is nothing, nothing but an abstract and contradictory view" (idem, *Philosophical Fragments*, 44).

⁶⁶Blaise Pascal, *Pensées* (trans. A. J. Krailsheimer; Baltimore: Penguin, 1996) §263.

⁶⁷Ibid. §282.

with all their light whatever they see in nature can bring them to this knowledge, find only obscurity and darkness.”⁶⁸

Pascal, like R. Nahman, pitied the one who defines his faith by rational proofs, however convincing those proofs may be. He asserted that whoever seeks God through reason “find(s) only obscurity and darkness.”⁶⁹ For R. Nahman, the person who enters into rational dialogue with the second heretic will conclude that divine absence is all that exists. While Pascal had pity for the person of reason, R. Nahman, apparently less confident in having permanently overcome the absence and having cleansed himself of the second heretic, retained a dialectical framework. To argue that R. Nahman would agree with Pascal that reason is the handmaiden of faith would overstate the case. Only by confronting reason, however, can R. Nahman’s theory of reaching beyond the void be understood.

With regard to R. Nahman and his use of the mystical tradition, Arthur Green has correctly noted that Weiss, in his bold typology, deleted the mystical dimension of R. Nahman’s position.⁷⁰ Green notes, “Nahman’s position is, on the one hand, that of a simple fideist who lives the life of Torah because God has commanded it, on the other hand that of a mystic who strives to reach such a state of oneness with God that the divine Will becomes entirely his own.”⁷¹ Hasidism in general, emerging out of the kabbalistic thought of the *Zohar* and subsequent Kabbala, viewed itself as an authentic form of Jewish mysticism, never rejecting the theurgic, mythic, and even magical context of medieval Kabbala.⁷² Although the mystical experience of the divine may indeed challenge R. Nahman’s striking vali-

⁶⁸Ibid. §242. See also Lucien Goldman, *The Hidden God: A Study of Tragic Vision in the Pensées of Pascal and the Tragedies of Racine* (trans. Philip Thody; New York: Humanities, 1964) 22–40, 167–92.

⁶⁹Pascal, *Pensées* §242.

⁷⁰Green states (*Tormented Master*, 318–19): “As we closely examine certain passages dealing with the very heart of Nahman’s ‘existential’ teachings, the constant struggle to search out integrate *maqqifin* we find that the end of that process is in fact mystical, in the most proper sense of the term.” Perhaps Green intends to make a distinction between the terms “mystical” and “kabbalistic” here. While R. Nahman indeed resolved the ominous trek through the void with a mystical perception of divine presence, the kabbalistic cosmological apparatus plays only a nominal role. Green’s observation thus questions the accuracy of the typology set up by Joseph Weiss in his *Studies in Bratzlav Hasidism* (Jerusalem: Mosad Bialik, 1974) 87–96 [Hebrew].

⁷¹See Arthur Green, *Devotion and Commandment: The Faith of Abraham in the Hasidic Imagination* (Cincinnati: Hebrew Union College Press, 1989) 55.

⁷²The use of and interest in magic and theurgy in hasidism is an area that is only now receiving scholarly attention. See, for example, Gedalyah Nigal, *Magic, Mysticism and Hasidism* (Northvale, NJ: Aronson, 1994); and Moshe Idel, *Hasidism: Between Ecstasy and Magic* (Albany: SUNY Press, 1995).

dation of the divine void, he incorporates the mystical experience as the reward for confronting the void and not falling prey to its fatalistic threat.

R. Nahman froze the Lurianic theory of creation in the midst of its dynamic process to focus not on the creation as such, but on the frozen frame of divine absence before it is filled with the finite form of divine presence. It is this frozen frame of *zimzum* to which R. Nahman devoted so much attention. He implied, perhaps, that if one seeks divine wisdom from “the bottom up” (that is, through nature and reason alone), one can never reach the transcendent God who lies beyond creation. It is only by freezing the void before it apparently disappears that one can achieve the ultimate experience of God. This frozen frame is also, however, the residence of the heretical question, the empirical recognition of divine absence which must be overcome by reenacting the creative process and then participating in the wordless scream, which is the divine soul’s pure yearning for its home beyond the void. For R. Nahman this ominous journey, which he apparently travelled daily, is the narrow bridge; spanning the abyss below, this journey connects the yearning soul to its place in the divine. Not to undertake the journey is to be a carrier of R. Nahman’s simple faith and thus to be satisfied with the immanent God of creation. To step onto the narrow bridge is to step into the void, with the roaring rapids below and the transcendent God calling from the other side.